



The latest Apple A15 Bionic SoC on iPhone 13 lineup

is that the Xiaomi 11T Pro even supports 120W fast charging, compared to the S21 Ultra's 25W fast charging.

All that, and you save a whopping ₹60-65K, depending on the storage model. While some may be able to afford the Samsung Galaxy S21 Ultra, from a monetary standpoint it makes very little sense to go for it over the Xiaomi 11T Pro, especially in India with the Exynos chipset that not only affects the performance but also the battery life.

If you're looking to be more prudent with your money, one of the first things you can ensure is buying one generation older phones. A year after a phone is launched and its next-generation counterpart has released, phones' prices take quite a substantial plunge while still being adept performers.

For example, in 2022, we are seeing phones with Snapdragon 8 Gen 1 processors in flagship devices, however, the performance and battery life is only incrementally better than the previous-gen Snapdragon 888 devices. You can even purchase refurbished year-old phones which will cost you significantly lesser. There are some companies such as CEX that provide warranty on their refurbished gadgets, making them a really good deal. Also, hold off on upgrading your smartphone every year or two since modern-day smart-

phones can easily last 3-4 years with some minor repairs or servicing.

The best practice is to buy a smartphone with tangible leap in technology from the device you already own. So, the jump from an iPhone 12 Pro to iPhone 13 Pro isn't one that is a large enough generational leap to justify the cost, but the leap from an iPhone 10 or 11 to an iPhone 13 is massive, especially in terms of battery and camera.

### TYPES OF USE CASES

As we mentioned earlier, value is subjective and is primarily dependent on the use case for each person. Let's go through four major use cases in the smartphone segment and see how you can get VFM here.

#### Camera

Smartphone manufacturers are constantly trying to up the camera megapixel count or rear camera count to entice users. However, higher megapixel counts don't always translate to better pictures. It is a good idea to note the brand and size of the lens as well. For example, Sony lenses are historically better than Samsung ones. Additionally, a bigger lens will allow for better low-light pictures. So, these factors must be kept in mind by smartphone camera enthusiasts when choosing a phone.

### Gaming

When choosing a smartphone for gaming purposes, one must consider the SoC and GPU used. iPhones are excellent for gaming purposes since Apple's silicone rarely disappoints. If you're on the Android side of things, for now, Qualcomm Snapdragon chipsets paired with Adreno GPUs still reign supreme. MediaTek chipsets do really well in benchmarking tests, but that doesn't always translate to real-world speed. Samsung's Exynos chips are inferior to the their Snapdragon versions – for speed and thermals. Mali-based GPUs used with Kirin and Exynos chips also usually don't match up to their closest competitors using Adreno-based GPUs.

### Battery life

Modern-day smartphones are getting increasingly power-efficient due to better optimised SoCs and the adaptation of more AMOLED displays. If battery life is your primary concern, the iPhone 12 and 13 lineup have excellent battery life, all past 8 hours of on-screen time. However, much more inexpensive phones around the ₹15-30K also come with massive battery capacities now such as 5,000 to 6,000mAh, providing days' worth of usage. In our experience, the cheaper phones are also more and more providing speedy charging speeds of 50-60W, allowing users to charge their device to full in less than an hour. So, if battery life is your main concern, you really don't need to spend a lot.

### A good mix of all

If you're looking for smartphones with a good mixture of all features, smartphones from brands such as Xiaomi, Oppo, Realme, and even OnePlus (although they're reaching flagship-level prices now) offer pretty good value for money. These brands also have good after-sales service in India, meaning you can make the phones last for even 3-4 years with some minor repairs (unless you're clumsy with them, of course). 